Conclusion

Over seventy years, India and China have not been able to agree on very much – on the delineation of the border, on the status of Tibet, and on appropriate military actions and behaviours. In the 1950s, both saw the other as insincere and stubborn in the border discussions. They concluded that the other had failed to honour commitments on Tibet. And they came to regard the other as militarily aggressive and themselves as militarily defensive. Having said that, now and then their differences on the border did narrow, they agreed on the status of Tibet (in 1950/51 and 1954), and they tried to avoid escalatory military actions. In the end, though, the points of convergence faded away. Both sides were at fault for letting slip the opportunities for striking a deal and avoiding war, and probably the best period was between their first encounters in 1949 when the communists came to power in China and 1954 when Nehru went to Beijing to meet Mao and Zhou.

In the decades after 1962, they normalized relations, negotiated on the border for nearly forty years, reaffirmed Chinese sovereignty in Tibet (with China reciprocating on Indian sovereignty in Sikkim), and instituted a series of military confidence-building measures. In 2005, it looked as if they had made a breakthrough on the border settlement. Within a year, that positive moment was gone, to be replaced by Chinese territorial claims that were even more extensive. In 2013, 2014, 2015, 2017, and finally in 2020, Indian and Chinese troops faced off in the biggest military confrontations since 1967. In January 2021, reports suggested that China had built a village four to five kilometres beyond the McMahon Line into Indian territory, south of Migyutin, where in 1959 China had accused India of intruding. This suggested that the western and eastern sectors of the border could become flashpoints simultaneously.

Why after seven decades can India and China not agree on anything vital relating to their perimeters? One answer is that they still do not trust what the other is saying and doing: India and China do not accept each other's historical claims to territory, do not believe their commitments on Tibet, and